



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 15

ILLINOIS

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Illinois's family courts and child-welfare system.

80

ILLINOIS FAMILIES ON RECORD · 116
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 2, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

31 OF 102

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

ILLINOIS AT A GLANCE.

Across 80 Illinois families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 116 79 of 80 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$20,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 50.0% 32.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 80	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 79 of 80	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 31

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Illinois families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF ILLINOIS FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	57	\$20,000	\$69,716	\$3,973,800
Lost Wages	54	\$20,000	\$88,815	\$4,796,000
Other Court Fees	28	\$525	\$2,832	\$79,300
Therapy / Evaluations	44	\$2,000	\$5,465	\$240,480
Reunification Services	34	\$350	\$1,557	\$52,925
GAL Fees	47	\$5,000	\$12,521	\$588,500
Asset Loss ¹	43	\$30,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$77,875	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$30,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		28	2.3 yrs
Total across all families		1,515	126.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · ILLINOIS

Most families documenting in Illinois are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		47	59%
Not provided		18	22%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		7	9%
Case closed: within last 2 years		6	8%
Experienced as a child		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		32	40%
Family Court Only		29	36%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		9	11%
Unknown		9	11%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

5 – 10 years		18	22%
1 – 3 years		15	19%
3 – 5 years		14	18%
Over 10 years		11	14%
6 months – 1 year		9	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		29	36%
Visitation Only		16	20%
50/50 Joint		12	15%
Children in Foster Care		8	10%
Full Custody		6	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Cook		11	14%
Sangamon		3	4%
Kane		3	4%
Grundy		3	4%
Madison		3	4%
Lake		3	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		26	32%
High Conflict Divorce		12	15%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		9	11%
Other: (Short answer)		9	11%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		4	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — ILLINOIS

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Illinois comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Illegally refuse to return my children due to false allegations and put my children in harm's way and cause them physical sexual and emotional abuse

— KRYSTAL BRIDGEMAN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Judge listened to ex parte communication from stepmom which she filed a third party intervenor to my divorce case after my ex has died. Put a false Order of Protection against me with no hearing until it was dismissed a year later by my lawyer. My ex husband worked with everyone [...]

— ILLINOIS PARENT · KATHLEEN

MORE VOICES FROM ILLINOIS

Destroyed every chance of me having a normal life and family. Cause my kids trauma and heartbreak they should have never been through

— HOLLY

The judge and opposing attorney covered up sexual abuse that my ex-boyfriend did my two children. The court, and the opposing attorney and the prosecutor contrived child abduction against me, made it appear as if I was not even the mother or sole custodial parent of my children. [...]

— MISTY

They have terminated my rights cps in illinois is major corrupted even when all services were completed they still Adopted my children out to a women who could have children and was close to a caseworker

— ELIZABETH

Family court has destroyed the innocence and robbed the dreams of my children and my motherhood. Family court has become the abuser and the weapon of my abuser. Family court is responsible for creating poverty homelessness and generational trauma.

— STEPHANIE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Dcfs the Chicago police the cook county public Guardians office and the cook county states Attorneys office along with the Attorney General's office violated all of my family's civil rights and my children suffered horrible irreparable physical damage for 16 years without a [...]

— JERRY

The system has terrorized and tortured me. They have stolen my son, my kids brother. And they have created lifelong scars that will never heal.

— LAUREN

Dcfs took my children during covid. I've missed out on so much, they ruined our lives.

— JENNA

The courts and GAL have allowed my ex to use the children to try to hurt me and have destroyed a happy healthy relationship I had with my boys. The court has and still is illegally taking disability income for things other than child support under threat of jail.

— DEREK

It has destroyed my life and my child is suffering in the hands of our abuser.

— LINSI

This system has deprived me and my children's rights and destroyed my family. There is nothing that can bring back the time they stole with my children.

— JENNY

Separated a two parent family from a child over false allegations. I am an indigent american veteran with not income for over a year fighting for my benefits. They have destroyed me financially knowing I have no income.

— THOMAS

The system has destroyed two children and maybe more as a sexual predator has access to the children's friends who he has started giving gifts to which he hides in his room. The GAL threaten my withness with fostercare if she didnt go back to her abuser now my child talks [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my hopes & my dreams. Took away the only thing I ever wanted to be the most of and that was being the best mother I could be to my girls. My life was flipped upside down over night. I had idea my baby daddy was working with CPS behind my back.

— JENNIFER

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



It's completely destroyed us both emotionally and physically.

— AMANDA

It has failed me from being a parent to my kids when I had done nothing wrong. My mother has paid off judges and lawyers to help take my children from me. She made friends with the mayor of the town and his wife going and having dinners with them, she made friends with the [...]

— KAYLA

Enable the abuser to continue using our child as a pawn

— MELISSA

This corrupt system has broken, stole, lied, and humiliated my family.

— AMANDA

Destroyed everything. Scarred my child.

— CAITLYN

Severe PTSD for me and trauma for my children. Tragically limited the potential of my children's future from what it could have been.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Kidnapped our 3 children and drove my wife 2 hours away for a psych evaluation while I was out of town for business

— BRANDON

Losing my 2 oldest was the hardest not being hear in my youngest case is even worse I currently have only one case going in family court and my mental health is still used against me. If there was a way to get all my kids back I would but IL is so corrupt and I get turned down [...]

— HANNAH

I am absolutely destroyed. All I do is cry for my child. I can't eat or sleep. The system has ruined my life. I am in law enforcement and question our legal system to the point where I no longer believe in the child civil side of it and Divorce side

— JASON

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Caused us separation anxiety due to family disruption.. trauma pain.. health problems

— CHERRY

Destroyed time cannot get back.

— KATE

I have lost the daily relationship with my only child. She is 4 and they forced her to stay with her abuser. I am only allowed to have 1 supervised visit for 1 hour a week only. I lost my job, car, apartment and had to file bankruptcy.

— GINA

They didn't just take my children from me, they took my stability, my time, my peace, my reputation, my ability to work, my trust in people, and two years of my life I can never get back."

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My caseworker has not only erased me, she nearly has buried me.

— MISTY

It's made my faith in Christ impenetrable. I believe in his promise—all things work together for the good of those who love the Lord.

— KATIE

Mentally kidnapped my kids

— RYAN

Broken me, making my daughter hate me, putting a lot of stress on my current family

— JOSE

It has taken away my son who loves child from our family and her sisters

— ST

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Has destroyed our family and left my son mourning the disappearance of his father, grandfather, grandmother, aunts, uncles and his cousins and all his friends. We are mourning a child that is still alive.

— VICTOR

DEVASTATED the family , ruined our lives

— ANDREA

Split family, kept father from child for 1 year Child trauma

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Post separation abuse from my ex, refusal to hold him accountable for violating court orders

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined my life & taken time away me nor my family will never get back. TRAUMATIZED US

— SAMANTHA

Alienation of my Children

— JUSTIN

Made us out to be the bad guy without looking into anything

— CHRISTY

Ripped my family apart. Caused conflict and abandonment with my family. Prolonged my ppd and made me go through pain from c-section due to not filling my prescription for pain medication in fear that a dirty test regardless of prescription would cause devastating damage.

— REBECCA

Caused stress in the household constantly watching who we talk to and what's said.

— CHRISTY

A judge suspended all of my parenting time with my son, relief no one asked for, despite every single evaluator opposing restriction, no finding of endangerment, and a written order acknowledging my conduct didn't warrant professional intervention; my child was taken not because [...]

— STAVROS

taken everything away from me and my child's current and future

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

57 Illinois parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — ILLINOIS

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Illinois families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Illegally refuse to return my children due to false allegations and put my children in harm's way and cause them physical sexual and emotional abuse

— KRYSTAL BRIDGEMAN

Destroyed every chance of me having a normal life and family. Cause my kids trauma and heartbreak they should have never been through

— HOLLY

The judge and opposing attorney covered up sexual abuse that my ex-boyfriend did my two children. The court, and the opposing attorney and the prosecutor contrived child abduction against me, made it appear as if I was not even the mother or sole custodial parent of my children. They used that crime that they falsified to steal my children from me and keep them from me. There was never a custody hearing, there was no custody switch. It was just their contrived crime. There was no GAL. The judge would not allow a GAL.

— MISTY

They have terminated my rights cps in illinois is major corrupted even when all services were completed they still Adopted my children out to a women who could have children and was close to a caseworker

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The system has destroyed two children and maybe more as a sexual predator has access to the children's friends who he has started giving gifts to which he hides in his room. The GAL threaten my witness with fostercare if she didnt go back to her abuser now my child talks sexually with adult men online and I was told that I monitor her to closely and was told I could not monitor them. I am a cyber security engineer who has worked on child monitoring apps for fortune 10 companies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Destroyed my hopes & my dreams. Took away the only thing I ever wanted to be the most of and that was being the best mother I could be to my girls. My life was flipped upside down over night. I had idea my baby daddy was working with CPS behind my back.

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It has failed me from being a parent to my kids when I had done nothing wrong. My mother has paid off judges and lawyers to help take my children from me. She made friends with the mayor of the town and his wife going and having dinners with them, she made friends with the sheriff and cops and any one who was elite and of importance. She talked bad about me to my community and I couldn't even go into a grocery store and hold my head up high because everyone was giving me looks. My kids love me and my mom is brain washing my kids into thinking I'm a bad mom and that she is their mom now. It has tore me and my kids life apart. I have two other daughters now and they don't get to see or be involved

— KAYLA

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— KATHLEEN

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

A judge suspended all of my parenting time with my son, relief no one asked for, despite every single evaluator opposing restriction, no finding of endangerment, and a written order acknowledging my conduct didn't warrant professional intervention; my child was taken not because I failed him, but because a system with no accountability decided it could.

— STAVROS

taken everthing away from me and my child's current and future

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has caused irreparable damage to my young children. We can never get their childhood back. They are continually punished for things over which they have no control. God will provide justice in the end.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I will never get my sons and daughters back in the same condition as when they were taken. Sadly, they too have lost the mother they were kidnapped from.

— MONIQUE

Dehumanized and robbed us, then asked to pay for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Yeah, the system has refused to adjudicate one fact in every single case in every single file and every single quote while acting on allegations in here say without any factual evidence from the other side and I'm not exaggerating

— JEFFREY

Has ripped my teenage daughter away placed her in behavior hospital where she's mentally declined because no placement so she's imprisoned against will drugged daily and begs to come home the PTSD inflicted will cause her to never ask for help and our case warranted a intact get your crap together first but they chose removal

— BOBBIE

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Having to grieve the loss of children that aren't dead is something that can't be put into words. The pain is unbearable but you have to survive in case they come back...it's a horrible way to live.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is taking my 5 year old daughter from her mother and siblings on fake alienation claims without viewing any of my children's sexual abuse evidence

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The damage to my family is catastrophic. Its been 9 years of torment. My youngest son was only 2 yrs old, and I've been told he doesn't remember me and thinks my exes current wife is his mom and they let him think so. Hes 11 years old now. Ive haven't seen my daughter either and I have no idea if she remembers me at all. My oldest is 22 now and we are just beginning to have a relationship. I am grateful for that but I mourn the relationship we used to have, the one we should have, the one we deserve to have. None of us are the people we would have been, we are all more broken, all more damaged, changed, robbed of our rightful place in each other's lives and not one person is better for it. A family destroyed for nothing.

— AMBER

Put me to the brink of death or wanting to kill

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system failed me as a child in the welfare system, at 30 years old seeing no real change, accountability or resources while my children are now in DCFS custody is quite scary, they're understaffed and not held accountable. We now live in fear waiting for reunification, in which we have been targets of DCFS since 2019.

— STARKESHIA

I have made it to the other side, my fear is that it will take my son a long time to heal from the emotional damage. I have NEVER lost my faith in God and he has carried me through.

— TIFFANY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Over years of litigation and ongoing conflict, the family court process and my ex's conduct have created instability, severe emotional strain, and division within our family, placing the children in the middle of adult issues instead of protecting their emotional, mental and physical wellbeing. The repeated litigation, financial instability, interference with parenting time, and ongoing conflict have significantly impacted both me and the children emotionally, mentally, physically, financially, and relationally, while undermining consistency and security for the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My daughters repeatedly ask for mom. I've seen my oldest daughter's school portal where she writes letters to me that she isn't allowed to send. Her doctor has reached out to me asking why her father hasn't brought her to her regular checkups for her medical condition. He lies and says she resides with him when eyewitnesses have stated they have seen all other members of his family except do my daughter. My youngest (with the other man who is now my ex's bff) is confined to a playroom, is in full time year round daycare while her father sits unemployed in a million dollar home asking me for child support (i work part time and rely on family help). I watch as he tells her that she is happy after she expresses she had a bad day or is sad. She has said she doesn't have friends.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

57 full approved Illinois comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Illinois report comes from Illinois respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Illinois — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 80 Illinois families reporting here are not the universe of Illinois families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.